

downgrading of posts flagged by independent fact-checkers and Twitter's (X) former "birdwatch" community notes system show that design interventions can reduce the reach of false content.

E: Empowering individuals with critical thinking skills addresses the demand side of fake news, while holding platforms legally and ethically responsible for their algorithmic amplification addresses the supply side. Neither approach is sufficient alone; literacy without systemic change places an unfair burden on users, while top-down regulation without an educated public can feel authoritarian.

L: Ultimately, building a healthier information ecosystem requires us to be both smarter consumers and more demanding citizens, advocating for technology that serves public discourse rather than undermines it.

Chapter 3: The Power of a Question

第三章：问题的力量 (Wèntí de lìliàng)

Your Goal for This Chapter 本章目标 (Běn zhāng mùbiāo): To understand how the questions we ask shape the answers we find. You will learn to deconstruct essay prompts and generate your own powerful, researchable questions.

理解我们提出的问题如何塑造我们找到的答案。你将学习解析论文提示，并生成自己强大的、可供研究的问题。

Lesson 3.1: The Engine of Inquiry

第一课：探究的引擎 (Tànjīu de yǐnqíng)

Part 1: Why Questions Matter

为什么问题重要 (Wèishéme wèntí zhòngyào)

Every piece of academic writing, every essay, every discovery, begins with a question. The quality of your question determines the quality of your answer.

每一篇学术写作、每一篇文章、每一个发现都始于一个问题。你问题的质量决定了你答案的质量。

A poor question leads to a poor answer.

一个差劲的问题会导致一个差劲的答案。

- **Weak Question 薄弱的问题 (Bóruò de wèntí):** "What is climate change?" (This leads to a simple summary, not an argument.)
“什么是气候变化？”（这会导致简单的总结，而不是论证。）
- **Strong Question 强大的问题 (Qiángdà de wèntí):** "To what extent should governments in developing economies be held responsible for reducing carbon emissions, compared to developed nations?" (This leads to a complex, argument-driven essay.)
“与发达国家相比，发展中国家政府应在多大程度上承担减少碳排放的责任？”（这会引出一篇复杂的、论证驱动的文章。）

Your ability to ask a strong question is your most powerful academic skill.

提出一个强大问题的能力是你最强大的学术技能。

Part 2: Deconstructing Essay Prompts

解析论文提示 (Jiěxī lùnwén tìshì)

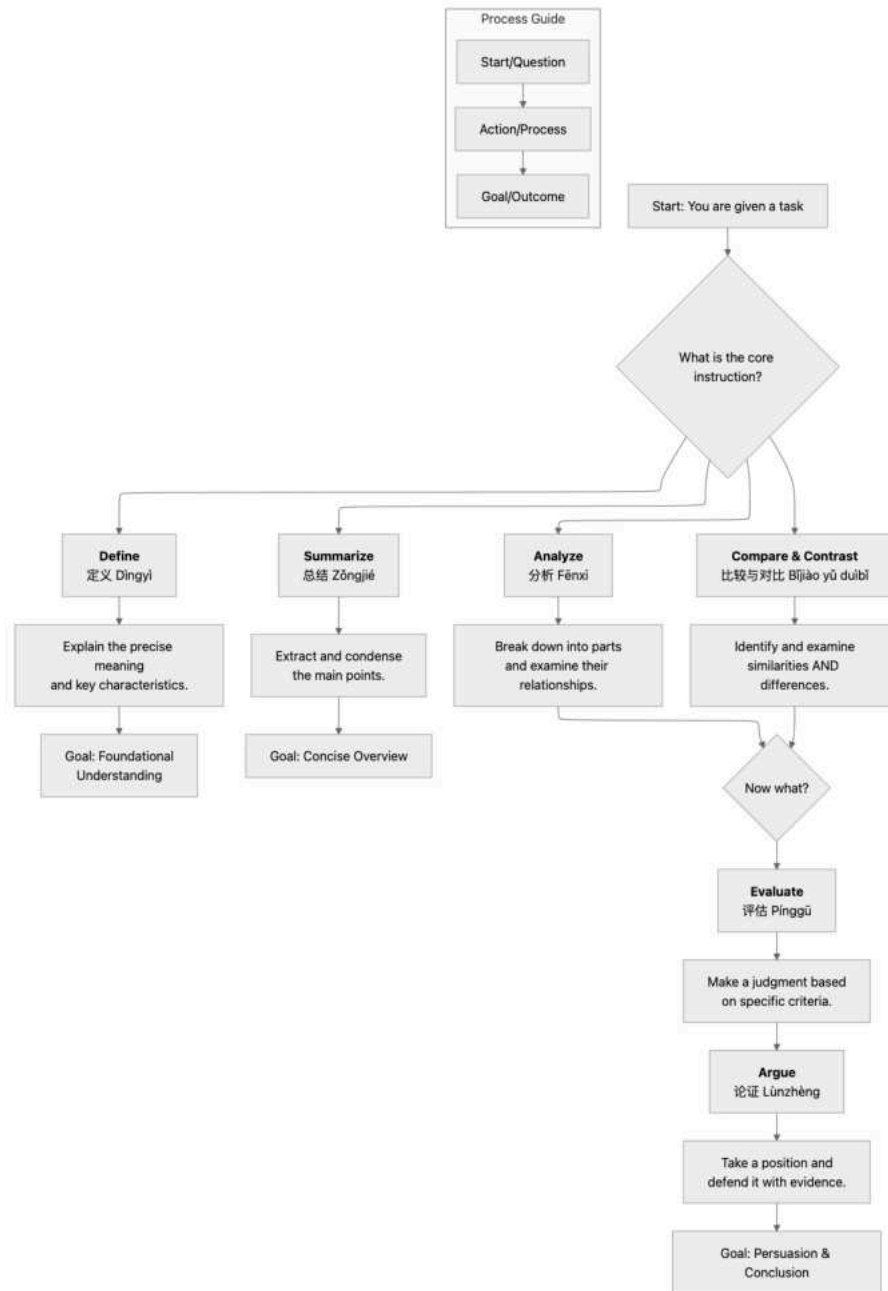
Before you can answer a question, you must understand what it is really asking. Most essay prompts contain a **command word 指令词 (zhǐlìng cí)** that tells you what to do.

在回答一个问题之前，你必须理解它真正在问什么。大多数论文提示包含一个告诉你该做什么的指令词。

Match the Command Word to Its Meaning 将指令词与其含义匹配:

Command Word 指令词 (Zhǐlǐng cí)	What It Is Asking You To Do 它要求你做什么	Example 例子 (Lizi)
Analyze 分析 (Fēnxī)	Break down a topic into its parts and explain how they work together. 将一个主题分解成部分，并解释它们如何协同工作。	<i>Analyze</i> the impact of social media on political campaigns. 分析社交媒体对政治活动的影响。
Compare & Contrast 比较与对比 (Bǐjiào yǔ duìbǐ)	Examine the similarities and differences between two or more things. 检查两个或更多事物之间的相似性和差异性。	<i>Compare and contrast</i> the economic policies of two world leaders. 比较和对比两位世界领导人的经济政策。
Evaluate 评估 (Pínggū)	Make a judgment about the value or success of something. Provide criteria for your judgment. 对某物的价值或成功做出判断。为你的判断提供标准。	<i>Evaluate</i> the effectiveness of the United Nations in maintaining global peace. 评估联合国在维护全球和平方面的有效性。
Argue 论证 (Lùnzhèng)	Take a position on a debatable topic and support it with evidence. 就一个可辩论的话题采取立场，并用证据支持它。	<i>Argue</i> for or against the use of animal testing in medical research. 论证支持或反对在医学研究中使用动物试验。
Summarise 总结 (Zǒngjié)	Give a brief overview of the main points of a topic without your own opinion or analysis. 简要概述一个主题的要点， 不要 加入自己的观点或分析。	<i>Summarise</i> the key events of the American Civil War. 总结美国内战的关键事件。
Define 定义 (Dìngyì)	Explain the meaning of a concept, often by outlining its key characteristics. 解释一个概念的含义，通常通过概述其关键特征。	<i>Define</i> the concept of 'sustainable development' and its core principles. 定义“可持续发展”的概念及其核心原则。

Flow Diagram Mind Map: Understanding Command Words



How to Read and Use This Mind Map:

The diagram shows a logical flow from basic comprehension to complex critical thinking.

1. **Start at the Top:** You begin with a task or question.
2. **Identify the Core Instruction:** The first step is to identify the key command word in your prompt. This sends you down the correct path.
3. **Follow the Path:**
 - **Define & Summarise (Left Branch):** These are foundational tasks focused on **understanding and restating** information. They are often the first step before more complex tasks.

- **Analyze & Compare & Contrast (Center Branch):** These are core critical thinking tasks. They require you to **dissect and examine** information. Notice how both of these tasks lead to a new question: "Now what?" This is because analysis and comparison are often done *in order to* do something else.

4. **Synthesise and Persuade (Right Branch):** The most advanced tasks build upon the others.

- **Evaluate:** After you have analyzed or compared something, you are often in a position to **make a judgment** about its value, effectiveness, or success.
- **Argue:** Evaluation naturally leads to argumentation. Once you have formed a judgment, you can **take a position and persuade** others of its validity using the evidence gathered from your analysis, comparison, and evaluation.

This map demonstrates that these command words are not isolated; they are interconnected tools for building a strong and logical response.

Activity: Identify the Command 活动：识别指令

For each prompt below, circle the command word and write what you think you are being asked to do.

对于下面的每个提示，圈出指令词并写下你认为被要求做什么。

1. **Critique** 评论 the author's use of symbolism in Chapter 3.

- I need to 我需要: _____

2. **Discuss** 讨论 the causes of the Great Depression.

- I need to 我需要: _____

3. **To what extent** 在多大程度上 do you agree that technology has improved communication?

- I need to 我需要: _____

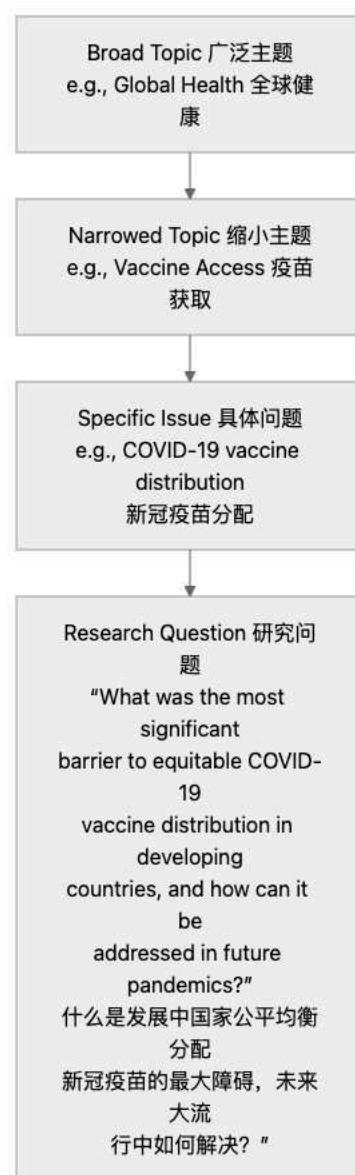
Lesson 3.2: The Power Of Questions

第二课：提出自己的问题 (Tíchū zìjǐ de wèntí)

Part 1: The Question Funnel

问题漏斗 (Wèntí lòudǒu)

How do you move from a broad topic to a powerful, focused question? You use a **Question Funnel** 问题漏斗 (Wèntí lòudǒu). 你如何从一个广泛的主题过渡到一个强大的、聚焦的问题？你可以使用问题漏斗。



Let's Practice 让我们练习:

Start with this broad topic: **Artificial Intelligence (AI) 人工智能**

1. **Narrow it down 缩小范围:** Choose one specific aspect of AI.

选择人工智能的一个具体方面。

- Example: AI in education, AI and privacy, AI and art, self-driving cars.

• **My narrowed topic 我缩小后的主题:** _____

2. **Find a specific issue 找到一个具体问题:** What is a problem, debate, or recent development within your narrowed topic?

在你的缩小主题中，存在什么问题、争论或最新发展？

- Example: How AI grading software affects student learning.

• **My specific issue 我的具体问题:** _____

3. **Form a research question 形成一个研究问题:** Use a command word to turn your issue into a question.
使用一个指令词将你的问题转化为一个问题。

- *Example: "Evaluate the effectiveness of AI grading software in providing meaningful feedback to students."*
- **My research question 我的研究问题:** _____

Recap - Choosing a research question



Part 2: Using AI to Fuel Inquiry

使用AI助力探究 (Shǐyòng AI zhùlì tànjiū)

AI is a powerful tool for exploring questions. It can help you quickly understand the basics of a complex topic.

AI是探索问题的强大工具。它可以帮助你快速理解一个复杂主题的基础知识。

Activity: Question Storming 活动：问题风暴 (Wèntí fēngbào) **Your Topic 你的主题 (Nǐ de zhǔtí):** Choose a topic you are interested in (e.g., a hobby, a current event, a historical figure).

选择一个你感兴趣的主题（例如：爱好、时事、历史人物）。

1. **Write your topic here** 在这里写下你的主题: _____
2. **Open Perplexity or DeepSeek.** Ask it: "What are some current debates or unanswered questions about [your topic]?"
打开Perplexity或DeepSeek。询问它：“关于[你的主题]目前有哪些争论或未解答的问题？”
3. **Skim the results 浏览结果.** Find one or two questions that seem interesting and complex.
找到一两个看起来有趣且复杂的问题。
4. **Write them below** 在下面写下它们:
 - **Question 1 问题一:** _____
 - **Question 2 问题二:** _____
5. **Reflect 反思:** Which of these questions could be the basis for a good essay? Why?
哪个问题可以成为一篇好文章的基础？为什么？

Part 3: The "So What?" Test

“那又怎样？”测试 (“Nà yòu zěnyàng?” cèshì)

A good academic question must pass the **"So What?"** test. If your question is answered, does it matter? Does it have implications?

一个好的学术问题必须通过“那又怎样？”测试。如果你的问题得到了解答，它重要吗？它具有意义吗？

- **Fails the Test 未通过测试:** "How many planets are in our solar system?" (The answer is a fact; it doesn't lead to debate or deeper understanding.)
“太阳系有多少颗行星？”（答案是一个事实；它不会引发辩论或更深的理解。）
- **Passes the Test 通过测试:** "How should we define a planet, and what does the debate over Pluto's status tell us about the nature of scientific classification?" (The answer has implications for how we understand science itself.)
“我们应如何定义行星，关于冥王星地位的争论告诉我们科学分类的什么本质？”（答案对我们理解科学本身具有意义。）

Apply the Test 应用测试: Look back at the research question you wrote in Part 1.

回头看你在第一部分写的研究问题。

- **Ask yourself 问自己:** "So what? Why does the answer to this question matter?"
“那又怎样？这个问题的答案为什么重要？”
- **Write your answer 写下你的答案:**

If you can't answer the "So what?" clearly, you may need to refine your question to make it more significant.
如果你不能清晰地回答“那又怎样？”，你可能需要改进你的问题，使其更重要。

Homework: The Art of the Question

作业：提问的艺术 (Tíwèn de yìshù)

Task 1: Deconstruct 解构

Look at the essay prompts below. For each one:
在网上或从其他课程中找到两个论文提示。对于每个提示：

1. Circle the command word. 圈出指令词。
2. Paraphrase what the prompt is asking you to do. 解释该提示要求你做什么。

Example

1. Analyze how the narrative structure of a non-linear novel (such as *Slaughterhouse-Five* by Kurt Vonnegut or *The God of Small Things* by Arundhati Roy) contributes to the development of its central themes.

- **Circle the command word: Analyze**
- **Paraphrase:** This prompt asks me to break down the complex narrative structure of a chosen novel (one that doesn't tell the story in a straight chronological line). I need to examine its components (e.g., flashbacks, time jumps, parallel storylines) and explain in detail how this specific structure shapes, reinforces, and deepens the reader's understanding of the book's main ideas or messages.

Your Turn

2. Compare and contrast the economic policies of Keynesianism and Monetarism, focusing on their core principles, their approaches to government intervention, and their proposed solutions for managing inflation.
3. Evaluate the effectiveness of international sanctions as a tool for compelling political change in authoritarian regimes. Support your position with specific historical or contemporary examples.
4. Argue for or against the proposition that advancements in artificial intelligence and automation will ultimately lead to a net increase in societal well-being, rather than widespread unemployment and inequality.

5. Summarise the central arguments of Thomas Hobbes' *Leviathan* regarding the necessity of a powerful sovereign, and explain how his view of the "state of nature" justifies this conclusion.
6. Drawing from philosophical and sociological sources, define the concept of "social capital." In your essay, differentiate it from other forms of capital (e.g., economic, cultural) and discuss its role in fostering community resilience.

Task 2: Create 创造

Choose one of the broad topics below and use the **Question Funnel** to create one strong, argument-driven research question.

从下面的广泛主题中选择一个，使用问题漏斗创建一个强大的、论证驱动的研究问题。

- **Broad Topics 广泛主题:**
 - Social Media 社交媒体,
 - Climate Change 气候变化,
 - Globalisation 全球化,
 - Education Technology 教育科技,
 - Mental Health 心理健康

My Chosen Topic 我选择的主题: _____

My Research Question 我的研究问题: _____

Task 3: Evaluate 评估

Run your research question through the "So What?" test. Explain why the answer matters.

用“那又怎样？”测试来检验你的研究问题。解释为什么答案很重要。

Example Example Homework: The Question Craft – Grading Rubric & Example

This assignment is a **Coursework Assessment**. It will be graded on a scale of 0–10 points.

Grading Rubric

Criteria	Excellent (9–10 pts)	Good (7–8 pts)	Satisfactory (5–6 pts)	Needs Improvement (0–4 pts)
Task 1: Deconstruct Prompts	All command words are correctly identified. Paraphrases are accurate, insightful, and demonstrate a	Command words are correctly identified. Paraphrases are	Some command words are misidentified. Paraphrases are vague or partially inaccurate.	Command words are largely incorrect. Paraphrases are missing,